

it's all too easy to see more of this cynicism than wonder. No matter where someone draws their joyous inspiration, someone out in the world, some nameless voice in the ether, tells them how boring, insipid, and pedestrian it is. The world tears down dreams and seeks to make them mundane.

Changeling: The Dreaming is a roleplaying game, played using the book you're reading now, a bunch of 10-sided dice (which can be bought at game stores or through online retailers cheaply — it's best for each player to have a set of 10 or so, but you can by with fewer), and some friends (collectively called the *troupe*). Together, using the rules and concepts in this book, you'll create characters for a **Changeling chronicle**, the overarching tale that the entire troupe experiences.

One player has a special role — she'll be the Storyteller. The Storyteller designs the chronicle, which the other players take part in and advance with the Storyteller's help, using their characters. The Storyteller describes scenes and plays important supporting characters, and the players describe how their characters react to these events. The Storyteller reacts to that, and so it goes.

All games have rules, and **Changeling** is no exception. The rules in this game help determine whether characters' actions succeed or fail, and give a Storyteller and her players a framework and system for their chronicles. When a particularly dramatic moment occurs in the story, or it just includes an exciting element of chance, the players and Storyteller roll dice using the rules in this book to determine the outcome.

Of course, maybe you knew all this already. The name of this game isn't just **Changeling: The Dreaming**, it's **Changeling: The Dreaming 20th Anniversary Edition**. This game is a love letter to everyone that's ever played **Changeling** in the last 20 years, and everyone who will play it going forward, as much a nostalgia piece as a new game. Before we dig too much deeper, it might be good to talk about where **Changeling's** gone, so we know where it's going.

Dream Diary: History of the Game

In 1995, **Changeling: The Dreaming** was released. It stood as a hard counter to the grim, gothic settings of its predecessors **Vampire: The Masquerade**, **Werewolf: The Apocalypse**, **Mage: The Ascension**, and **Wraith: The Oblivion**, at least at first glance. **Changeling** was a modern fantasy game about the souls of fae in human bodies, trying to keep the world magical and full of dreams by going on adventures and exploring... because if they failed, the boring, plain reality of the World of Darkness would unmake them, and humanity might lose the ability to dream forever. The apparent conflict in tone and new concepts such as a CCG-styled card system for powers wasn't for everyone, and yet the game ultimately found enough fans to produce a second edition.

Changeling's second edition discarded some of its predecessor's odder rules and filled in holes in the setting and metaplot, bringing the game more in line with other World of Darkness games of the time. Unfortunately, despite the game's strong,

dedicated fanbase, the line was first moved to a smaller publishing imprint in 1999, then canceled entirely in 2001. It got a spin-off in 2004 as **Dark Ages: Fae**, but only one book was released before the classic World of Darkness, and **Changeling** with it, ended in the **Time of Judgment** book.

The best dreams never die, though, so here we are again in 2016 with a new edition of **Changeling: The Dreaming**, taking the best from every era of **Changeling** and tuning it to fit the years of game design evolution it missed out on. While this game is partly a celebration of **Changeling**, and fanservice for all the dedicated players out there, this is also a new edition of the game, a jumping-on point for players that never got into **Changeling** the first time around. Whoever you are, wherever you come from, welcome. Let's tell a story.

Arcadia and the Dreaming

Have you ever had the feeling that your dreams were more than your brain clearing detritus at the end of a long day? The feeling that imagination was really tapping into something great and powerful? That somehow, clapping your hands really *did* bring back Tinker Bell? Then you've got an idea of the Dreaming: A world of hope, fear, fantasy, beauty, and terror where dreams are reality.

It's called the Dreaming because that's the closest a person can come to truly understanding it. It doesn't make sense, there's no internal logic, anything can change in a heartbeat, but when you're there it feels more real than anything you've ever experienced — just like dreams. The Dreaming is in a symbiotic relationship with what we'd consider the real world. Humanity's imagination gives power to the Dreaming, and in turn the Dreaming inspires humanity towards great things.

Deep within the Dreaming lies Arcadia, the home of the Fair Folk. The Kindly Ones. Faeries. These inhabitants of the Dreaming are living stories, creatures of narrative given agency and individuality, acting out great adventures in the Dreaming and Arcadia alike. Nobody actually knows what Arcadia is like, or at least nobody that can be asked, but it's thought of as an idyllic, perfect world, a paradise for the Fae. At some point in the last 600 years, the doors to Arcadia slammed shut. The Dreaming and mundane reality became more defined, separated but still coexisting. This was bad news for the Fae on Earth at the time, as they couldn't get back. They were cut off from their homeland, trapped on Earth — a world with dreams, certainly, but not a world of dreams. The Glamour that humans created wasn't enough to protect them from Banality, the cold, hard fact that sometimes in the World of Darkness, dreams aren't enough. Banality is poison to Fae, and as the world they were exiled to grew darker and more Banal, the Fae that had not found safety in Arcadia or lost themselves to the madness of the raw Dreaming were nearing extinction.

It was then that the Changeling Way was created.